

Leila Tewahade

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Honolulu, HI

EDUCATION

Hawai'i Pacific University, Honolulu HI

2022 – 2026

B.S. Biology: Conservation, Ecology, & Evolution; Minor: Oceanography

Honors: Class Valedictorian, Dean's List (all semesters), Marine Science Scholar

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant: Understanding and controlling the spread of the invasive coqui frog (*Eleutherodactylus coqui*) on O'ahu, Holland Lab July 2025 –

Supervisor: Dr. Brenden Holland

- Conducting swabbing of invasive coqui frogs (*Eleutherodactylus coqui*) to test for chytrid fungus (*Batrachochytrium dendrobatidis*, Bd)
- Developing experimental protocols to monitor and track coqui movement using radio telemetry
- Contributing to grant proposal development including literature review and methods writing

Undergraduate Research Assistant, Holland Lab

Jan 2026 –

Supervisor: Dr. Brenden Holland

May 2026

- Assisted in the collection of Talitridae amphipods from O'ahu beaches
- Performed molecular techniques including DNA extraction, PCR amplification, and gel electrophoresis

Undergraduate Research Assistant, Iacchei Lab, Lobster Phyllosoma Project

Nov 2025 –

Supervisors: Alondra Reyes, Dr. Matthew Iacchei

May 2026

- Measured and assessing morphological features for staging of lobster phyllosoma larvae
- Assisted with molecular identification techniques including DNA extraction, PCR amplification, gel electrophoresis, and ExoSAP cleanup for lobster phyllosoma species identification

Undergraduate Research Assistant, Iacchei Lab, CoralNet Project*Supervisors: Sophia Samus, Dr. Matthew Iacchei*Sept 2024 –
Jan 2026

- Identified organisms in images of intertidal cage experiments conducted on Hawai‘i Island using CoralNet
- Organisms included ‘opihi, helmet urchin (*Colobocentrotus atratus*), various macro-algae, crustose coralline algae, and additional marine invertebrates

Undergraduate Research Assistant, Iacchei Lab, Ciguatera Project*Supervisors: Kelsie Kuniyoshi, Mylou Matur, Dr. Matthew Iacchei*Aug 2024 –
Aug 2025

- Supported field collection of target limu species via free-diving and processed samples through filtering and subsampling
- Quantified *Gambierdiscus* spp. using microscopy to support projects studying ciguatera fish poisoning risk in O‘ahu communities

Undergraduate Research Assistant, Iacchei Lab, ‘Opihi Project*Supervisors: Sophia Samus, Dr. Matthew Iacchei*July 2024 –
Aug 2025

- Assisted a graduate student in field experiments on ‘opihi makaiauli (*Cellana exarata*) by collecting morphometric and physiological measurements and recording environmental parameters

Undergraduate Research Assistant, CMDR*Supervisors: Katie Stevens, Mafalda de Freitas*May 2024 –
Aug 2024

- Analyzed and entered data for derelict fishing gear (DFG) and marine debris events around O‘ahu
- Assisted with analysis and data entry of plastic debris samples collected from Palmyra Atoll
- Contributed to community-based mitigation efforts through sorting and disposal of marine debris collected from Maui, Kaua‘i, and O‘ahu

Undergraduate Researcher, Neuroscience Lab*Supervisor: Dr. James Lawrence*Jan 2023 –
May 2025

- Developed and conducted protocols utilizing electroencephalogram (EEG) technology
- Coordinated timelines and scheduling and led collaborative projects
- Trained and mentored new research assistants in experimental protocols and data handling procedures.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant – BIOL 2052: Gen. Biology II, Hawai'i Pacific University

Jan 2025 –
May 2025

Supervisor: Dr. Jessica Jacobs

- Led weekly recitation classes for ~30 students that reinforced lecture material covering plant biology/taxonomy, animal biology/taxonomy, and general ecology
- Graded weekly recitation assignments and exams
- Proctored exams.

VOLUNTEER EXPERIENCE

- Participated in community-based invasive coqui monitoring including hand capture efforts and citric acid treatment preparation
- Assisted with forest habitat restoration through invasive plant removal and outplanting of native plants
- Participated in limu outplanting to support community-driven ecosystem recovery efforts
- Moved rock to help restore the kuapā and weeded kalo patches at He'eia Fishpond

SCHOLARSHIPS / GRANTS

- **Hawai'i Invasive Species Council Grant:** Understanding and controlling the spread of the invasive coqui frog (*Eleutherodactylus coqui*) on O'ahu (\$46,651)
- **United States Department of Agriculture NextGen Internship**
- **IDeA Networks of Biomedical Research Excellence Grant:** Neural Processing Related to Cognition, Sensory Processing, and Stress-Reduction Techniques (\$3000)

TECHNICAL SKILLS / CERTIFICATIONS

Spatial/Statistical: ArcGIS Pro; R/RStudio

Other Field Experience: Oceanographic field sampling aboard 42-foot research vessel

Molecular/Laboratory: DNA extraction, PCR amplification, gel electrophoresis, ExoSAP cleanup; Microscopy and plankton identification

Data/Software: Microsoft Excel; CoralNet image classification

Certifications: PADI Open Water Diver; CITI Biosafety & Biosecurity Level 3